Fusion of functions revisited: Independent determinatives in English

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Abstract

The Cambridge Grammar of the English Language (*CGEL*) analyses independent determinatives, as in *take some*, *some of the wine*, and *the lucky few*, with fused functions: one word realizes Head together with Determiner or Modifier. Holding *CGEL*'s separate determinative category fixed, I argue that ordinary Head relations do better. In bare, partitive, and externally determined uses alike, the determinative heads a nominal that heads the noun phrase, so *the lucky few* has the structure of *the lucky survivors*. For determinatives, *CGEL* ties the fused modifier-head to a use as internal modifier: *the few* is licensed by *the few mistakes*. Attested *the some who* has no such counterpart: *some* has no internal-modifier use, and in the corpus lines checked, the string *the some people* turns up only as typos and a stray *the*. The available repairs (converting *some* to a noun, a construction-specific rule, or a weaker licensing condition) each add a stipulation that ordinary Head avoids. Ordinary Head also lets *CGEL*'s complex determinatives *a few*, *a little*, *a great many*, and *many a* be analysed as peripheral modification by *a* and predeterminer modification by *many*, as their expansion (*a good few*) and agreement (*a few are*, *many a man is*) suggest, and it keeps the modifier contrasts *CGEL* draws in *almost every* and *hardly anyone present*. Fusion remains where it has independent work, with adjectives (*the idle rich*). This isn't the DP hypothesis: a determinative in Det remains a dependent of the noun it determines.

Keywords: determinatives; fused heads; headedness; noun phrase; quantifiers; English grammar

AI use. The large language models GPT-6 (Astra), Claude Fable 5.1, Claude Opus 5 and 5.5, Claude Haiku 4.5, GLM-5.3-Flash, and GPT-5.6 (Sol) served as drafting and editing aids throughout the preparation of this paper. I am responsible for all theoretical claims, arguments, errors, and interpretive choices.

1 Introduction

TODO: allocated from the combined manuscript in step 2.

2 Background

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3 Analysis

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4 Discussion

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5 Conclusion

Independent determinatives don't need fused functions. With *CGEL*'s categories unchanged, an ordinary-Head analysis gives bare, partitive, and externally determined uses a single chain: the determinative heads a nominal, and the nominal heads the noun phrase. That groups *the lucky few* with *the lucky survivors*, not with *the idle rich*, and it treats independent *few* alike with and without *the*. It also needs fewer constituents with two parents: fusion's shared node stays where adjectives need it, not where determinatives do.

The case that separates the analyses is *the some who*. For a determinative, *CGEL*'s licence for a fused modifier-head is a use as internal modifier, and *some* has none. So fusion has two options: list *the some* as an exception, as *CGEL* already does for *the both of us* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 377), or weaken its own condition. A conversion analysis has a problem of its own. The one attested conversion of *some*, a writer's *nones and somes* for the religiously unaffiliated and affiliated, behaves as a converted noun does: it takes plural inflection and adjectives (*Catholic or Protestant somes*) and names a group by a property. *The some who* keeps the quantity reading of independent *some* instead. That doesn't exclude every conversion, since nouns such as *lot* quantify too, but the converted noun would have to keep exactly the properties of independent *some*. Under ordinary Head no fused-head licence is needed, only the lexical permissions every determinative has, and the rarity of *the some* has a plausible semantic source: existential *some* adds little once *the* has identified the set.

The same structure retires the complex determinatives. In *a few*, *a little*, and *a great many*, a peripheral *a* modifies an NP headed by *few*, *little*, or *many*. *Many a* has predeterminer *many* before an *a*-NP, like *such a* and *what a*. The decomposition rests on *CGEL*'s own record: *a few* admits *very*, *good*, and *fair*, and agreement follows the parts, plural after *a few* and singular after *many a man*. Their restrictions, including the polarity contrast between *few* and *a few*, become conditions on those modifiers.

Fusion remains for adjectives, where it has independent work, and for the nominal *nylon* and *double* constructions. The open question is phrase structure. If determinative-headed and genitive expressions turn out to need different constraints once their lexical restrictions are held fixed, separate phrase types would be favoured. Nothing here depends on whether determinatives are a kind of noun. A grammar that keeps them a separate category adopts the analysis by licensing ordinary Head for both categories.

References

Huddleston, R., & Pullum, G. K. (2002). *The Cambridge grammar of the English language*. Cambridge University Press. https://doi.org/10.1017/9781316423530